

Interactive Beat Annotation GUI

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Introduction

Contextualization and Problem Framing

Music Information Retrieval (MIR) is a research field that develops computational methods to analyze, interpret, and retrieve musical information from audio, examples include: harmony, melody, rhythm, and structural elements. Within MIR, Beat Tracking (BT) focuses on the automatic extraction of musical beat information from recordings. Since the beat provides a fundamental temporal framework for music, BT is a critical component of many MIR systems.

“Many MIR systems first analyze the beats as the starting point, assume the results would be correct, and use them as a unit for further processing.” (Yamamoto, 2021)

The beat is typically defined as a regularly occurring pulse that underlies the temporal organization of a musical piece. However, the perception of the beat can vary across listeners. An objectively definitive beat can only be established if it is explicitly defined by the composer or agreed upon by performing musicians.

BT has been a research focus for decades. Existing algorithms perform reliably for music with steady, predictable tempos, such as Pop music. In contrast, music with expressive and/or fluctuating tempos remains challenging for autonomous beat detection. Examples of music genres that are still difficult to assess are, classical, jazz or world music. These can make the process of beat tracking more complex and ambiguous.

For this reason SoTA BT autonomous algorithms are all machine learning (ML) based. And although there are a few that are self-supervised (Desblancs et al., 2023), these are usually genre specific or are bound to certain musical configurations. For the cases that SoTA BT still can't solve, human-made beat annotation (or revisions) are still the most reliable.

Although there has been a lot of effort in advancing autonomous BT solutions, the same can not be said for human focused BT tools where it seems that they have been stayed largely unchanged for years now.

Research Questions

With this, there are a couple of research question that summarize the problems that we intend to tackle:

1. How can we improve the accuracy and efficiency of contemporary beat annotation workflows?
2. How can we make an effective music score representation, that can be aligned to show notes in their absolute time positions?
3. How can we make such score align with a spectrogram view of the recording?

State-of-the-Art

Beat tracking Research

- Autonomous BT performance discussion //explicar que hj os BT são à base de ML
- SoTA vs expressive music limitations //falar nos casos onde BT ainda n consegue dar resultados decentes
- Evaluation metrics (F-measure) //será que preciso de falar sobre isto
- Clear separation between: Algorithmic BT -VS- Human annotation practices //ok talvez isto faça sentido

Current SoTA beat tracking methods are predominantly based on neural networks (CNN, TCN's, Transformers) and they can achieve excellent performance scores (F1-scores >0.9).

POR ACABAR

Beat Annotation Methods

- ~~Tapping-based annotation~~
- ~~Motor noise, jitter, latency~~
- Need for correction and shifting operations, ELABORAR MAIS

For music in which autonomous SoTA BT systems aren't efficient enough, relaying on human made beat annotations still might be preferable to the annotator:

“A common method to create beat annotations for music recordings is to let a human annotator tap along with them.” (Driedger et al., 2019)

The problem with this, is that these annotations will probably not be accurate enough even if the user performing them is an experienced musician. There are multiple reasons that stem from perception, human motor noise, jitter and system latency (Driedger et al., 2019). Thus when tapping, there is the need to shift marked beats in order to make them accurate:

“This shifting operation is particularly relevant when correcting tapped beats, which can be subject to human motor noise as well as jitter and latency during acquisition.” (Sá Pinto et al., 2020)

Existing Tools for Beat Annotation

- ~~Sonic Visualizer~~
- ~~VAMP plugins~~
- ~~Export/import workflows (.txt)~~
- Emphasize *design intent mismatch* (general-purpose vs BT-specific), mmm será mesmo necessário?

Sonic Visualizer is still the go-to software for scientific and MIR purposed audio analysis. However when it comes to BT, SV is outdated due to it's inefficient BT labeling process, that is still very much manual and cumbersome (Yamamoto, 2021). SV also is heavily reliant on VAMP plug-ins, modern SoTA BT algorithms are complex ML applications that may be difficult to implement into VAMP plug-ins and/or there is no direct or valued incentive for making these algorithms available in this way.

Time Instances inside SV (name of the main tool in SV for BT), can be exported and imported as simple .txt files. Thus, for one to benefit from a SoTA BT algorithm, one needs to follow a few steps:

- First, one needs to have access the algorithm in itself which might involve not only browsing, but also probably, accessing some publicly available source-code repository.
- Secondly, one needs to know how to compile and run the program and export the retrieved data into a .txt file that SV can read.
- Besides this, we also need to take into account that to accomplish these steps, one needs at least, to be minimally literate/experienced with programming.

One problem with this, is that other users who may not be experienced in programming or literate in MIR research will rely on the most easily accessible BT algorithm inside SV, and these will probably be Beat Trackers like: BeatRoot (Dixon, 2001), Tempo and Beat Tracker - Queen Mary University of London (Stark et al., 2009), and IBT – INESC Beat Tracker (Oliveira et al., 2010) among others. The reason being that, although they don't come pre-installed with SV, they can be added via a SV native feature that allows to browse and install VAMP plugins without exiting the program (referring to the “Find Transform” SV feature). Crucially it is important to note that, as of the writing of this paper, you will not find any SoTA BT using this SV built in feature, in fact one will only find outdated BT that are at least more then a decade old.

One of the most common autonomous BT assessment mistakes are the Double/Half time errors, in which the algorithm might mark the beat in orders of integer multiplication (or division) from the actually correct beat.

Another common mistake might be inducing multiple closely sequenced markings in the place where only one should be, or the contrary, omitting/skipping beats. For correcting these type of mistakes, current Beat Tracking software only allow correcting beats one-by-one. A simple workaround for this mistake would be to develop a feature in which the user could select a time region of beats and perform an operation such as:

‘In this region, that start at xx:xx and ends at yy:yy , the tempo is a steady X bpm with Y/Z timeSignature.’ The program would then shift/eliminate/highlight marked beats that deviate from the “user statement”.

HIL Approach for BT

- ~~Yamamoto (2023)~~
- ~~Discussion of closed-source limitations~~
- ~~The Spectrogram Flaw~~

In 2021 Yamamoto proposed a Human-In-the-Loop (HIL) approach for BT, the problem is, although this paper seems promising, the software developed for this paper is closed-sourced, property of Yamaha Corp. and thus, it is not likely to be publicly accessible.

The paper also fails to mention how a spectrogram can be beneficial as opposed to the more conventional waveform representation of audio. A waveform can be useful for identifying general differences in energy, on the other hand spectrograms can, besides that, represent information related with spectral energy in time (frequency-energy).

A clear example of this would be: In a waveform, one can distinguish a *ff* section of from a *pp* in a recording. In a spectrogram, one can not only distinguish these, but also understand if a particular section would be chord hit, or an *arpeggio*, along side noticing where these note onsets would be located pitch wise.

Audio-to-Score Alignment for BT

• ~~Piano Precision~~

• ~~Audio-to-score alignment~~

Something that is not very well documented, is the relevance of following along a music score when performing a beat annotation. Besides helping the annotator follow along more accurately the recording, a score might notice the annotator in advance of any bpm or time signature changes. Besides that, when using a Spectrogram-Based view of the recording, one can distinctively align a specific onset to a concrete and exact moment in the recording timeline, this is essential to know if a beat is accurately assessed or not.

Piano Precision (Jiang et al., 2025), is an example of an SV fork that was designed for displaying musical scores alongside audio recordings in a unified graphical interface. This program works surprisingly well for classical Solo Piano pieces. Now there are two question that arrive from this:

- One is that, by following along the music sheet, Beat Tracking autonomously should be as straight forward as making the program align a beat marking with the respective note onsets that are marked in the score. Although for Piano Precision already does this with high enough accuracy for Audio-to-Score alignment, for beat tracking this adjustments might be needed, yet, it still gives a good starting point.
- The other would be to integrate this idea of Audio-to-Score alignment with a Spectral View of the recording. In PianoPrecision this is done via a side-window that displays the a single A4 page of the score, one at a time. When the user hits play, a darkened highlight displays the current playback position in the score, while in another window a spectral view of the audio is is following along the playback position horizontally. This allows for a musically natural follow-along of the score, mimicking how a musical score is actually read. However, for audio analysis and visualization purposes, it could be beneficial for the score to be aligned and viewed along side the playback position, meaning, horizontally and with note onsets that are aligned with their respective absolute position in the timeline. For BT this could allow the user to “grab a beat” and position it on the it’s corresponding position on top of the spectrogram representation. Also this could be beneficial for more easily detecting beats that should be shifted.

Identified Gaps

Add a synthesis subsection (currently missing)

This is crucial.

Summarize:

- Tooling gap
- Interaction gap
- Accessibility gap
- Visualization gap

This subsection should directly justify your contribution

Work Plan

12/February:	Submission of state-of-the-art report
20 to 24/April:	Intermediate presentation
15/June:	Submission of thesis for supervisor validation (SIGARRA)
30/June:	Validation by supervisors (SIGARRA)
13 to 24/July:	Public presentation/Defence
31/July:	Final version submitted (SIGARRA)

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